



SALES MEETING

Speed and service win the order

What the research says about first touch, follow-up, and support in industrial buying

Nate Gurski | Steel King Sales Team | September 2026



THE POINT

By the time a buyer contacts us, they have already picked a favorite. The first touch decides whether it stays us.

Eight in ten B2B deals go to the first vendor the buyer contacts. Most vendors take more than a day to answer.

AGENDA

Five things we cover

Why it matters, what the market shows, and what we change.

01	The market is showing up	5 min
02	The buyer decides early	10 min
03	Speed to lead	10 min
04	Service after the sale	10 min
05	What we change	15 min

01

The market is showing up

Demand for rack is real. The question is who gets the order.

MARKET

Racking is the top planned equipment buy

Buyers have budget and intent. We are competing for share, not for demand.

45%

PLAN TO BUY RACKS AND SHELVING

Top equipment category in the 2026 and 2025 MMH outlook surveys

\$542K

AVG PLANNED MH EQUIPMENT SPEND

Up from \$402K planned for 2025, a 35% jump

+18%

U.S. INDUSTRIAL CONSTRUCTION PIPELINE

305M sq ft under construction, Q2 2026, fourth straight quarterly rise

Every one of these buyers will shortlist fewer than five suppliers. Our job is to be on the list and stay on it.

02

The buyer decides early

Most of the decision is made before anyone calls a rep.

BUYER BEHAVIOR

The shortlist is built before we get the call

Buyers research alone, keep the list short, and mostly buy from the first vendor they contact.

62%

OF THE BUYING PROCESS DONE ONLINE

Engineers and technical buyers, before contacting anyone at the vendor

71%

VET FEWER THAN FIVE SUPPLIERS

Industrial buyers on Thomasnet; only 3% look at more than ten

8 in 10

DEALS GO TO FIRST VENDOR CONTACTED

B2B buyers across industries; favorites ranked before first contact

If the first call, form, or dealer inquiry goes unanswered for a day, we hand the order to whoever answered.

WHAT BUYERS WEIGH

Lead time and support outrank price

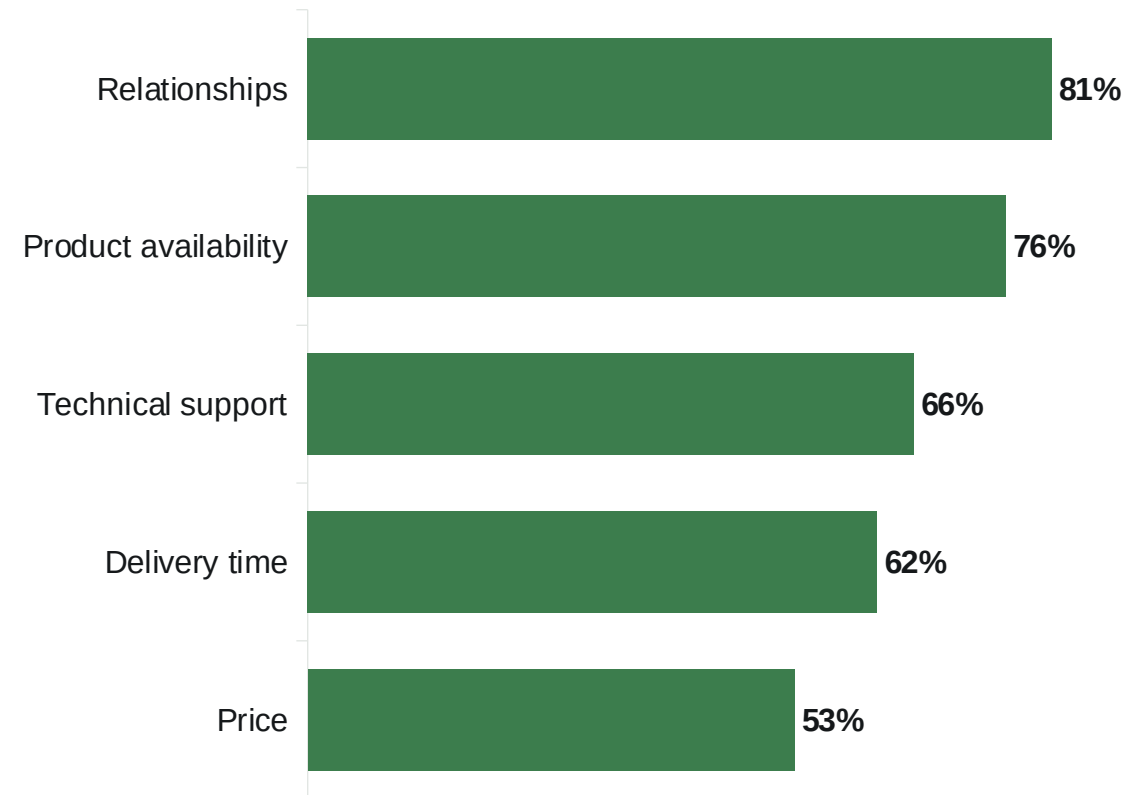
Industrial buyers rank lead time first when they shortlist. Price is fifth on why distributors win.

Thomasnet shortlist factors, in order: lead time and availability, unit price, quality certifications, verified company information.

Buyers expect an answer inside 24 hours. 44% say so outright.

One buyer, verbatim: "If I have to follow up twice, I eliminate you from consideration."

Rejection reasons: delayed or no RFQ response, having to follow up more than once, unclear pricing, stale company info.



Buyers want a rep who knows their business

Human help cuts buyer regret in half. Generic help gets us removed from the list.

WHAT BUYERS WANT

Only 6% of technical buyers want no salesperson. They call for technical complexity (47%) and pricing or inventory (40%).

66% of engineers rate the vendor's engineering experts as highly trustworthy.

86% of business buyers are more likely to buy when the company understands their goals.

Rep-assisted purchases carry half the regret of self-service buys: 21% vs 43%.

WHAT BUYERS REPORT GETTING

59% say most reps don't take the time to understand them.

73% say most sales interactions feel transactional.

69% see conflicts between the website and what the rep says.

Top deal killers: misleading price or product info (48%), not understanding the buyer's company (44%).

03

Speed to lead

The first hour is worth more than the next week.

RESPONSE TIME

An hour's delay cuts qualification odds 7x

The value of a lead decays by the hour. Most companies let it decay for nearly two days.

7x

MORE LIKELY TO QUALIFY

Contact within one hour vs. waiting one more hour

60x

MORE LIKELY TO QUALIFY

Contact within one hour vs. waiting 24 hours or more

42 hrs

AVERAGE RESPONSE TIME

Across 2,241 U.S. companies audited; 23% never responded

A lead that sits overnight is not the same lead in the morning. Speed is the cheapest advantage we have.

THE GAP

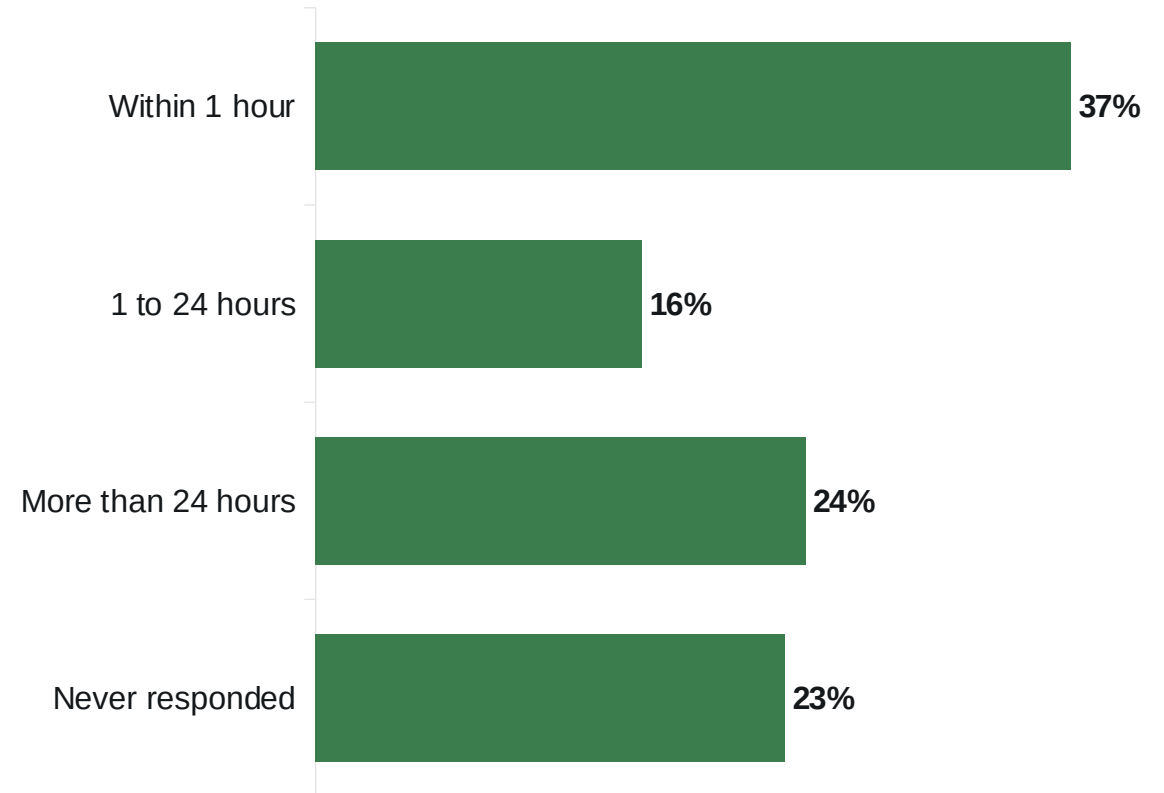
Most companies take a day or more to answer

Slow response is the norm. That makes fast response a differentiator.

Manufacturers and distributors: 71% take a day or more to produce a quote. 88% say they have lost deals to slow, manual quoting.

2026 test of 114 B2B companies: one sent a personalized reply within five minutes. None called within five minutes. Only 31% called at all.

Platform data across 5.7M leads: 77% of leads never got a response. Reps average 1.3 call attempts before giving up.



PERSISTENCE

Most reps quit after one attempt

Most deals need several touches. The second through sixth is where reps stop and conversions live.

Half of all leads are called only once. 93% of leads that convert are reached by the sixth call.

A six-call cadence lifted conversion 49%. Adding a five-email cadence lifted it 128% combined.

Average rep makes 1.3 call attempts before moving on.

New accounts take 8 touches on average to get a meeting. Top performers get there in 5 because each touch carries something useful.

Buyers told RAIN what they will tolerate: 55% accept 2 to 4 contacts, 23% accept 5 to 10. Persistence is expected, not resented.

Persistence runs one direction. We chase the lead. The buyer never chases us: "If I have to follow up twice, I eliminate you."

CREDIBILITY

The popular follow-up stats don't hold up

Every figure in this deck traces to a named study. These popular ones don't, so they're not here.

"80% of sales need 5 follow-ups; 44% of reps give up after one." Traces to a 1942 survey of under 40 door-to-door salesmen. No modern source.

"78% of buyers buy from the first company to respond." Attributed to a "Lead Connect survey" that no one can produce.

"35 to 50% of sales go to the first responder." A vendor blog assertion with no study behind it.

"The MIT study says 21x." It was a 2007 vendor-sponsored analysis by an MIT fellow, not an MIT publication. HBR's 7x and 60x are the clean numbers.

"A dissatisfied customer tells 9 to 15 people." Attributed to a White House office that never published it; the research is from 1979.

Why it matters: if we set standards on bad numbers, the first skeptic in the room wins. Use the sourced ones.

04

Service after the sale

Service response is now a purchase criterion, not a cost center.

SERVICE

Service response is now a buying criterion

Fast service response now ranks next to uptime. Poor service is the #2 reason buyers leave.

95%

**RATE FAST SERVICE RESPONSE
VERY IMPORTANT**

Warehouse automation buyers, 2026;
up from 83% a year earlier

41%

**OF BUSINESS BUYERS LEFT
OVER POOR SERVICE**

Second only to price (65%) as a reason
to stop buying

50%

**WOULD SWITCH FOR BETTER
POST-SALE SUPPORT**

U.S. industrial buyers; 87% of millennial
buyers say so

The install crew, the parts desk, and the engineer who calls back are part of the product. Buyers score them that way.

THE MATH

Retention pays twice. Churn costs for years.

Aftermarket carries double the margin of equipment, and a burned B2B customer stays gone.

WHAT SERVICE EARNS

Aftermarket services deliver margins more than two times higher than equipment sales alone.

97% of manufacturers are changing their service and aftermarket operations. Of those tracking satisfaction, only 44% are hitting their goals.

73% of chief sales officers now prioritize growth from existing customers over new logos.

Companies that run service as a value center grow revenue 3.5x faster than those that run it as a cost center.

WHAT POOR SERVICE COSTS

80% of frequent B2B buyers switched a supplier in 24 months because it could not meet their expectations.

66% of B2B customers stopped buying after a bad service interaction.

51% of them were still avoiding that vendor two or more years later.

Only 29% of B2B customers are fully engaged. Gallup calls the other 71% ready to take their business elsewhere.

Our response time becomes the dealer's

Dealers are being asked for contractor-grade service. Our response time is theirs.

86% of lift truck spend runs through dealers. Under 15% goes direct. Rack is not measured the same way, but the channel is the same.

MHEDA 2025: storage and handling customers now expect "contractor-like service capabilities" from the dealer.

MHEDA 2026 trends: rising customer expectations squeezing margins; manufacturer-distributor partnerships "becoming essential."

Hytrol's CRO to MHEDA members: for uptime-critical end users, response time has to be "within minutes, not hours."

Younger buyers research online and expect to buy online. 80% of industrial buyers would move to a supplier with a more usable web presence.

Every quote, drawing, and parts question a dealer sends us has an end customer waiting behind it.

05

What we change

Three standards, measured, owned, and on the scorecard.

Where this shows up in our own process

Six touchpoints we control. Each has a number behind it.

Touchpoint	What the buyer expects	The number behind it	Source
Web RFQ or contact form	A human reply the same day	7x more likely to qualify inside an hour. 44% expect an answer within 24 hours.	HBR 2011; Thomasnet
Dealer quote request	Price and lead time fast enough to hold their customer	Lead time is the #1 shortlist factor. 71% of manufacturers take a day or more to quote.	Thomasnet 2021; Aleran 2025
Application and drawings	A rep and an engineer who know the job	66% rate vendor engineers highly trustworthy. Rep-assisted buys carry half the regret.	GlobalSpec 2026; Gartner
Follow-up on an open quote	We chase. They never have to.	93% of conversions by the 6th call. "Follow up twice and I eliminate you."	Velocify 2012; Thomasnet 2021
Install, parts, and service	Same-day response with a named owner	95% rate fast service response very important. Poor service is the #2 reason buyers leave.	MMH 2026; Salesforce 2024
Existing accounts	Contact between POs, not just at PO time	73% of CSOs prioritize existing-customer growth. Aftermarket margins 2x equipment.	Gartner 2025; Deloitte 2026

STANDARDS

Three standards we hold ourselves to

Each one maps to a number in this deck. Each one gets measured.

01

1. First touch inside one hour

Every inbound lead, web form, dealer inquiry, and RFQ gets a human acknowledgment within one business hour. A real answer or quote inside 24 hours. Nobody waits two days to hear from Steel King.

02

2. Six touches before we close a lead

No lead is marked dead after one call. Minimum six touches across phone and email over two weeks, each with something useful: a drawing, a lead time, a reference. Log every touch.

03

3. Same-day service response

Post-sale questions, parts, and install issues get a same-day reply and a named owner. Dealer questions answered within four business hours. Response time reported monthly next to bookings.

ROLLOUT

Measure first, then set the bar

We cannot manage response time until we can see it. Baseline comes before targets.

OCT 2026



Baseline

Pull current response times for web leads, dealer RFQs, and service requests. Secret-shop our own inbound. Owner: Nate with inside sales.

NOV 2026



Standards and cadence

Agree the three standards. Build the six-touch cadence and templates. Assign lead ownership rules. Owner: regional managers.

DEC 2026



Tools and dashboard

Route leads with alerts. Response-time report by rep and by dealer. Owner: marketing and inside sales.

Q1 2027



Scorecard and review

Response time and follow-up rate on the sales scorecard. Review monthly in L10. Owner: Nate.

Source: Dates are proposed and can move with the team's input.



THE POINT

Nobody buys rack because we called back fast. They stop considering us because we didn't.

Speed and service don't win on their own. They keep us on the shortlist long enough for product and price to win.

ACTIONS

Next steps

What we agree to today, who owns it, and when.

Action	Owner	Date	Status
Secret-shop our own inbound (web form, phone, dealer RFQ) and report response times	Nate	Oct 15, 2026	Proposed
Pull 90-day CRM data: time to first touch and touches per lead, by rep	Inside sales lead	Oct 15, 2026	Proposed
Draft the six-touch cadence with templates and required content per touch	Regional managers	Nov 1, 2026	Proposed
Agree the three standards and the exceptions	Sales team	Nov sales meeting	Proposed
Lead routing alerts and a response-time dashboard by rep and dealer	Marketing (John) with inside sales	Dec 15, 2026	Proposed
Add response time and follow-up rate to the sales scorecard	Nate	Jan 2027 L10	Proposed

Owners and dates are proposed for discussion in the meeting.



What we decided

Three standards: first touch inside an hour, six touches before a lead closes, same-day service response. Baseline in October, on the scorecard by January.